

UNIFORMS OF EUROPEAN ARMIES

European military uniforms of the 18th century generally took the form of a tricorn hat, a waistcoat, breeches, canvas gaiters, and a coat with a long skirt. Infantrymen wore coats in national colours – blue for the Prussians, green for the Russians, and red for the British. One notable component of uniform was the elongated, brimless grenadier’s cap. The grenadiers were established in the mid- to late 1600s as an elite infantry unit of the tallest and strongest men, who attacked with heavy grenades from the front rank of the infantry. They chose a brimless cap to enable them to sling their musket over their shoulders and throw grenades more easily.



◀ RUSSIAN GRENAДИER’S CAP

Date 1762
Origin Russia
Material Silvered brass

The silvered-brass front plate on this grenadier cap bears the monogram of the Russian Emperor Peter III. After a reign of just six months in that year, he was succeeded by his wife, Catherine II (“Catherine the Great”).

Monogram of Peter III

Officer’s gorget

Officer’s sash

TRICORN HAT



▲ RUSSIAN OFFICER’S UNIFORM

Date 1687
Origin Russia
Material Broadcloth, silk

This uniform and tricorn hat of an officer in the elite Preobrazhensky Regiment of the Russian army was worn by Peter I (“Peter the Great”), who established the regiment in 1687. The regiment had significant success against Swedish forces in the Great Northern War of 1700–21, and later formed the bodyguard of Empress Catherine the Great.

► RUSSIAN GENERAL’S UNIFORM

Date 1760
Origin Russia
Material Wool, silk

This ornate uniform belonged to the Russian general Alexander Suvorov, who never lost a battle in his entire career. Shortly before his death in 1800 he was made Generalissimo of the Russian Empire, taking command of all Russian troops, following his masterminding of a tactical retreat across the Alps in 1799.

Decorated pocket

Green was the traditional colour of Russian infantry

